demonetisation was to be accompanied by a form of development bonds for rural areas, with no questions asked on sources of income. As Vajpayee put it:[4]

If we come to power, our solution would be this: we would for a specified period of time, allow people to invest in the industrial development of the backward areas of this country and also in the essential fields of production. We would not ask them to disclose the source of their money.

This along with demonetisation, would be the most practical way of solving the problem. Now for several years you and I and everybody have been hearing of the increase in the volume of black money. Various economists have made alarming estimates. Everyone knows that black money is wrecking our economy but can you solve a problem by just talking about it. Even the finance minister says now that black money is operating as a parallel economy. Well it is operating but what have they done about it? So let us be honest and try to tap this hoarded wealth for the development of the country and at the same time plug all loopholes in the tax evasion.

Modi revived the idea of demonetisation. Yet, this early Vajpayee intervention shows that the kernel for it was always there in the Jan Sangh's economic thinking. The BJP's predecessor, on two occasions, had passed economic resolutions specifically demanding that Congress governments take recourse to demonetisation: on 18 November 1972 and 16 July 1973.[5] It was not alone in doing so.

A deep dive into newspaper archives reveals that, from the mid-1960s to the mid-1970s, three future prime ministers of India—Vajpayee, I.K. Gujral and Chandra Shekhar—had demanded demonetisation during parliamentary debates on the economy.[6] For almost a decade (1967–1974), the idea enjoyed such cross-party support that it regularly featured in the parliamentary questioning of finance ministers after the presentation of the annual budget.[7] The state government of UP, led by Charan Singh and consisting of an anti-Congress coalition that included the Jan Sangh, even passed a